



**FRIENDS AND THEIR FOE**
US president Donald Trump with Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu at the White House, Apr. 7; Iran's supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei

AFP

## Return of Might is Right

What's concerning is that barring rhetorical noises from major powers like Russia and China, criticism of the brazen Israeli and US military strikes was muted. This was in sharp contrast to the UN Security Council passing a resolution censuring Israel for its attack on Iraq's Osirak research reactor in 1981. Israel claimed it was a one-off preventive strike. However, 45 years later, there is hardly any condemnation of Israel or US actions.

The US justified its strikes on Iran, with US defense secretary Pete Hegseth calling them necessary for America "to neutralise threats to our national interests posed by the Iranian nuclear programme and for the collective self-defence of US troops and our ally Israel". Gen. Naravane sees this collective self-defence approach as worrying, and points out, "The only tangible outcome of the current conflict is that unilateralism has come to stay and that might is right. Nations like Israel and the US are imposing their will without formal declarations of war or hostilities as Russia did when it invaded Ukraine in 2022. Now, no country in the world is safe. The big message is, if you don't toe the line, you are liable to get bombed. And if you don't have nuclear weapons, you are at their mercy. This is a dangerous turn in international affairs."

China seemed quite happy for Trump to get embroiled in the Middle East and the Ukraine-Russia conflict while building its strength to unilaterally take over Taiwan. Russia had its own vested interest for Trump to take his eyes off Ukraine and focus on other conflicts. In Europe, German chancellor Friedrich Merz endorsed Israel's attack on Iran, praising it for doing the "dirty work" of other countries. French president Emmanuel Macron urged "utmost restraint, de-escalation and return to the negotiating table".

**MANY BELIEVE THAT US AND ISRAEL ACTIONS HAVE SENT OUT THE MESSAGE THAT IF YOU DON'T TOE THE LINE, YOU WILL BE BOMBED. NO COUNTRY IN THE WORLD IS SAFE ANYMORE**

Most Arab powers, including Saudi Arabia, saw benefit in Iran's nuclear capabilities being degraded given the traditional Persian-Arab blood feud. So, while they condemned the attacks on Iran, the conservative monarchies are largely beholden to the US and had no option but to allow it to use their air space to bomb Iran. Some experts saw the combined US-Israel action as a paradigm shift in Middle Eastern geopolitics. "In the short term, it leaves Israel enormously strengthened at the expense of every other power in the Middle East," says Kumar.

Israel as a regional dominant power without a Muslim country to rival its ambitions is a serious threat and one reason why there will be no defusion of tensions. Especially if, as T.S. Tirumati, former secretary in the external affairs ministry, says, a Netanyahu emboldened by his Iran adventure decides to proceed with his dream of an 'Eretz Yisrael', or the promised land covering all the land from the river Jordan to the Mediterranean Sea. It could see Israel annexing Gaza and the West Bank too, though annexing Palestinian territories would put Israel in direct conflict with the surrounding Muslim nations and result in endless conflict. Already, with the mounting civilian bloodshed, Israel's